

had a revival in the 18th century in England, and the Ancient Order of Druids was founded in 1781. The arrival of modern archaeology unearthed new evidence of Celtic faith systems, and modern druidry, also called Neodruidry, developed in the 1960s.

Neopagans have also taken spiritual elements and rituals from earlier occult societies, especially the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn established in London in 1887 (see pp.242–243). The Romantic movement of early 19th-century Europe was another source of inspiration. Romantic painters and poets looked afresh at nature, awed by its beauty. Nature-based religions developed in the 1970s, linked to growing concerns about the environment, and many Neopagans now identify with ecological causes. Many more also champion feminism.



◀ Channeling energy

Dowsing is a form of divination that some Neopagans use to channel inner energies and locate sources of divine power. It is demonstrated here at Ardgrove Stone Circle in County Cork, Ireland, using a crystal pendulum.

Like druidry, Wicca is a significant branch of Neopaganism, but many groups are smaller. Subgroups include reconstructionists, who re-create and adapt pre-Christian religions, and followers of the gods of ancient Egypt, Greece, and Rome. Celticists reimagine the spiritual practices of ordinary Celtic people rather than those of the druids, and heathenists are inspired by ancient Norse and Germanic mythology. Some of these Neopagans have links with alt-right, Neo-Nazi, and white supremacist movements, glorifying an imagined pure Celtic or Viking past into a racist, often anti-feminist, ideology.

Apart from these far right-wing Neopagans, who see multiculturalism as a menace, all the other subsets of Neopaganism value tolerance, diversity, inclusivity, spiritualism, joy, and a delight in magic, and share the notion that others should never be harmed. Individual Neopagans, or small groups called circles, covens, or groves, are now found on every continent.

JOHN MICHAEL GREER (BORN 1962)

Leading light

A prolific and learned author who has written on a wide range of subjects from spirituality to ecology, US-born Greer is now a dominant figure in druidry across the globe. He has been highly influential in spreading druidic lore, teaching, and magic. Much of his work is derived from the 19th-century Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, and in 2013 he created a direct offshoot: the Druidical Order of the Golden Dawn. Between 2003 and 2015 Greer took the role of Grand Archdruid of the Ancient Order of Druids in America.

